

# Potential triggers do not always escalate

## Evidence from a pilot study

*Ways of speaking badly: Insults, slurs, and confrontational speech*

April 29th, 2026

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This research was supported by the Swedish Research Council VR projects 2023-00358 and 2014-39; ERC Starting Grant DivCon: Divergence and convergence in dialogue: The dynamic management of mismatches (101077927); the EXPEDIS (PID2021- 122779NB-I00) project funded by the Ministry of Science, Innovation and Universities/Spanish Research Agency/10.13039/501100011033 and ERDF "A way of making Europe"; and AGAUR grant 2021SGR00947.



# Research Goal

- How do confrontations start?
- Are there linguistic actions that systematically trigger confrontation?

# Why study how confrontation is triggered?

- Confrontation is common
- We can find ourselves in one without awareness of how we got there
- We might want to avoid them
- It is useful to know how they start, and how they are sustained



# Roadmap

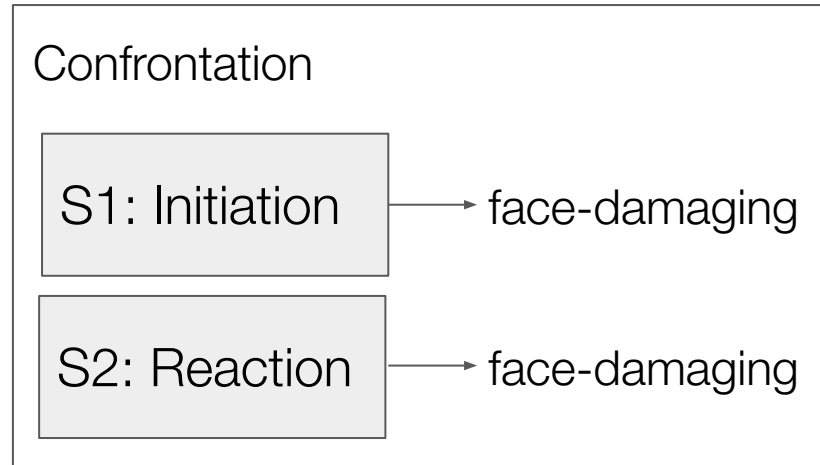
- Confrontation, face effects, and potential triggers
- Experimental study: do potential triggers systematically trigger confrontation?
  - Methodology
  - Results: no evidence to support that they do
- Motivation for further testing: limitations and participant feedback
- Reframing the RQ for future work

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# What is confrontation?

- 2 speakers
- 2 sequenced turns (actions): initiation and reaction
- Both the initiation and reaction cause face damage (Amido 2025)



# Face and face effects

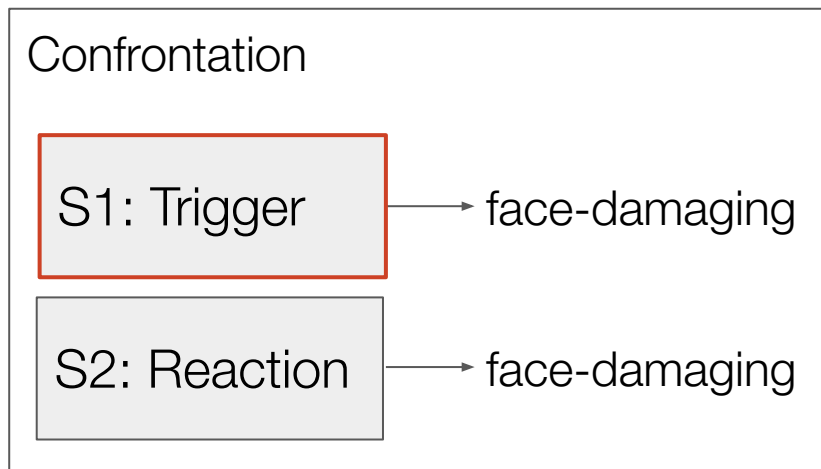
- Face: “One’s public self-image” (Brown & Levinson 1987)  
Face exists in mental states
- The want to be approved by others + the want to be free to act as one wishes
- Face effects are part of perlocution: what happens as a result of an action
- Actions can impede face wants (face damage)  
or support face wants (face enhancement)

# Corpus study: potential triggers

RQ: Are there actions that trigger confrontation?

## Methodology:

- *The Only Way is Essex* corpus (Amido 2025)
- Data: dialogues with confrontation
- Identified confrontation **triggers**:
  - recurring actions that cause face-damage
  - their reaction causes face-damage



# Corpus study: potential triggers

- Results

- Counters
- Addressee-centred assessments
- Negative assessments
- Rhetorical questions
- Metacommunicative directives
- Address terms

- Potential triggers (PTs):

They trigger confrontation in the analysed contexts

**But do they systematically trigger confrontation?**

# PT 1: Addressee-centred statements

- The speaker makes a statement about the addressee
- The addressee has epistemic authority on the matter

1 MEG: and **no:w cause you're**  
          **unhappy you're trying to**  
          **fuck my relationship up=**  
2 CHL: =no (I'm not 「at all」)  
          ((still laughing))  
3 MEG: **[by start]ing some shit**  
          **rumour**  
4 CHL: ((looks puzzled at Megan))



## PT 1: Addressee-centred statements

- Addressee-centred statements, when constrained by politeness, are usually mitigated or formulated indirectly (Kamio 1997)

*You are unhappy.*       $\xrightarrow{\text{[POLITENESS]}}$       *You seem unhappy.*

- “Displaying sensitivity to epistemic authority may be violated [in aggravated disputes]” (Kangasharju 2009)

## PT 2: Metacommunicative directives

- Expressions that manage the course of the interaction rather than contribute to the topical content
- Commands, suggestions, requests, etc.

## PT 2: Metacommunicative directives

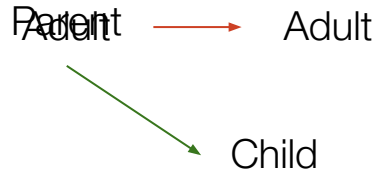
- 1 LCK: [yeah >↑you en'ed with me< wull ] **listen**
- 2 LCK: it's not an ideal situation <bu- wha- breakup is.>
- 3 LCK: and I don't thi:nk, me and you keepin <contact>, an' the constant messages, the constant .hhh keepin tabs on me?
- 4 YAZ: no and vice-versa=
- 5 LCK: =no, **listen**=
- 6 YAZ: =no(w) let's be honest 「you message l me as well=
- 7 LCK: [**listen**]
- 8 LCK: =no >no no< **listen**
- 9 YAZ: ((gestures with both hands))  
「↑no >no no< you l
- 10 LCK: [() if you] 「(don't me will leave) °let's lea:ve it alone° l



## PT 2: Metacommunicative directives

- Possibly perceived as patronising when interlocutors have equal status
- Imply addressee's inferior competence in, e.g. ability to hold a conversation  
(Hummert & Ryan 2001)
- Imply a power asymmetry in the speaker's favour, which is not viewed as legitimate by the addressee (Culpeper 2011)

*Stop shouting!*



## PT 3: Address terms

- The speaker uses the addressee's name utterance-finally
- It is not for the purpose of disambiguating who is being addressed

1 LCK: =.hh me an' you just didn't  
work (0.2) **Yaz**

2 LCK: an' [it's]

3 YAZ: [↑I ] know that >↑you haven't  
go-a tell me tha:-<=

4 LCK: [okay ]

5 YAZ: =L↑I endjed with you >I  
finished with [you cause I  
called you out<]



## PT 3: Address terms

- Used to “express a particular stance toward or relationship with” the addressee  
(Lerner 2003; see also Jefferson 1973 and Quirk et al. 1985)
- Used with “particularly significant or sincere” utterances (Clayman 2010)
- Quite vague, but could explain their trigger function if
  - Expressing a negative stance towards the addressee
  - Used with significantly or sincerely offensive utterances

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# The study

RQ: **Do these 3 potential triggers systematically trigger confrontation?**

- 40 participants (University of Gothenburg)
  - Students on campus (cinema voucher compensation)
  - Students in dialogue systems course (course credit)
  - English fluency (self-attested)
- 2 groups: control and intervention
- Task: 20 minute chat on Telegram (messenger app), discussing a moral dilemma
- Post-task rapport survey
  - 5 pt. Likert scale
  - Optional written feedback

# Moral dilemma

*There is a hot air balloon with four passengers in it. The balloon is losing altitude and will soon crash unless some weight is thrown overboard. Unfortunately, the only option to reduce weight is for one person to jump out of the balloon, sacrificing themselves to save the others. The four passengers are the following:*

- *Dr Robert Lewis – a cancer research scientist, who believes he is on the brink of discovering a cure for cancer*
- *William Harris – the balloon pilot who is the only passenger with any balloon flying experience*
- *Susanne Harris – William's wife, a primary school teacher who is 7 months pregnant with their second child*
- *Heather Sloan – a nine-year old musical child prodigy who is considered by many to be a "twenty-first century Mozart"*

# Interface

Dialogue Experimental Toolkit chat tool (Healy et al. 2003)

- a text-based chat interface
- runs on Telegram
- enables production of interventions in real time dialogue
- interventions are only visible to the recipient

# Interventions

| Potential trigger            | Programmed intervention                 | Conditions for production  |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Addressee-centred statements | Change / into <i>You</i>                | Turn must contain “I”      |
| Metacommunicative directives | Add <i>Listen</i> , utterance-initially | Turn must not end with “?” |
| Address terms                | Add <i>,p1/p2</i> utterance-finally     | Turn must not end with “?” |

Frequency of intervention production:

- Every 5 turns, insert random intervention
- For selected intervention, produce it iff the turn meets the conditions for production

# Dialogue excerpt example (w/interventions)

p1: Well I was thinking about Dr Robert

p2: Robert Lewis - pro: less weight, con: possibly no cure for cancer

p1: All we know about him is that he “believes” he is on the brink of discovering a cure

p1: He could be completely wrong

p2: True

p1: **Listen**, but we know for a fact that Heather is a child prodigy

p1: Who is considered a “twenty first century Mozart”

p1: Also Heather is still a child

p2: But is even the chance of possibly having a cure for cancer not worth more than music?

p1: But we don’t know the chance of having a cure for cancer

p1: He could be not close at all

p2: Also, not many child prodigies become actual geniuses, **p1**

p1: **Listen**, also how do we know there aren’t other scientists who are also that close to a cure for cancer

p2: How dp we know therw arent other child prodigies?

p1: That’s true

p2: And also, should we base their human worth on their possible achievements?

p1: I’m not sure

# Rapport survey (Gratch & Kang 2015)

- “The experience of harmony, fluidity, synchrony, and flow felt during a conversation”

| Higher score = higher rapport                                      | Higher score = lower rapport (reverse coded)         |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| I felt I had a connection with my partner.                         | I felt I had no connection with my partner.          |
| I think that we understood each other.                             | My partner created a sense of distance between us.   |
| My partner was warm and caring.                                    | My partner communicated coldness rather than warmth. |
| My partner was respectful to me.                                   | I wanted to maintain a sense of distance between us. |
| My partner created a sense of closeness or camaraderie between us. | I tried to communicate coldness rather than warmth.  |
| I tried to create a sense of closeness or camaraderie between us.  |                                                      |

Likert scale: **1** strongly disagree; **2** disagree; **3** neither agree nor disagree; **4** agree; **5** strongly agree

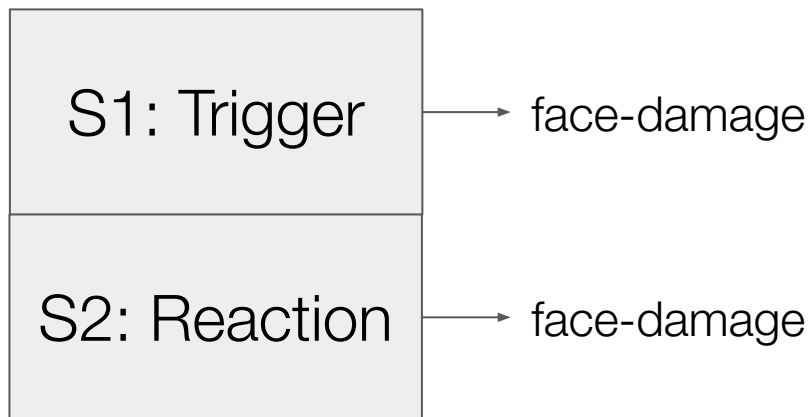
# Rapport survey (Gratch & Kang 2015)

- “The experience of harmony, fluidity, synchrony, and flow felt during a conversation”
- Assumption: confrontation is negatively correlated to *rapport*



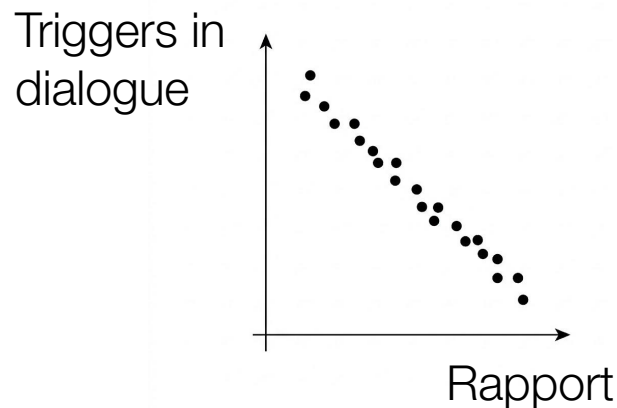
## Identifying confrontation triggers

**[Corpus study]** an action that causes face-damage, and has as reaction another face-damaging action



## Measuring confrontation

**[Pilot study]** lower perceived rapport with interlocutors = higher confrontation (due to cumulative escalation of triggers)



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# Overall group difference

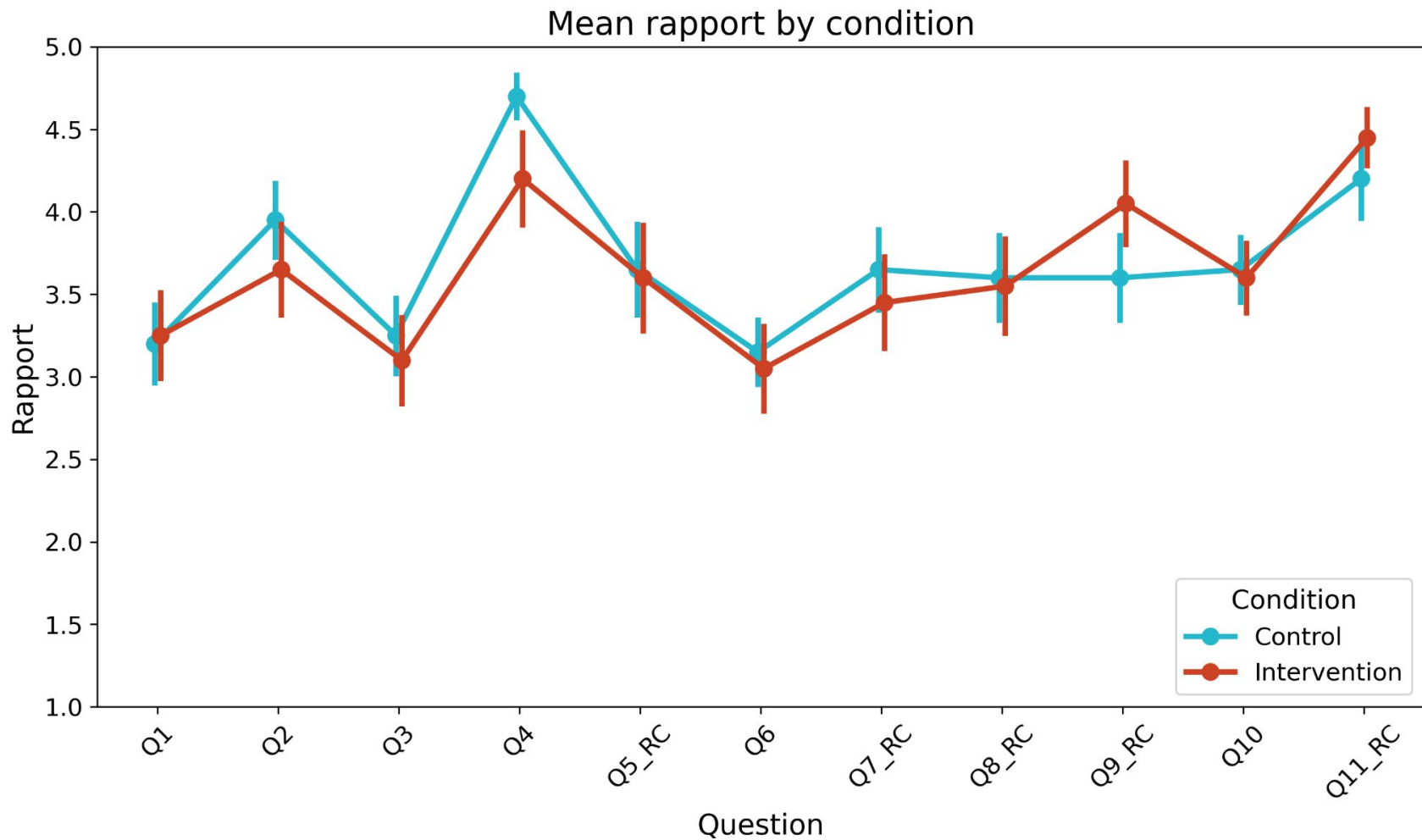
- Does condition (intervention vs. control) predict rapport?

```
Rapport ~ Condition  
          + (1 | Participant_id)  
          + (1 | Pair_id)  
          + (1 | Question)
```

- **Results**

Intervention condition:  $\beta = -0.059$ ,  $p = 0.794$

Intervention condition  $\rightarrow$  lower rapport scores, but not significant



# Intervention count

- Dialogue lengths varied (range: 20-115 total turns)  
Consequently, so did intervention count (range: 2-6 per participant)
- Does the count of interventions predict rapport (controlling for dialogue length)?

```
Rapport ~ Intervention_count  
          + Turn_count  
          + (1 | Participant_id)  
          + (1 | Pair_id)  
          + (1 | Question)
```

Turn count:  $\beta = 0.011$ ,  $p = .047^*$   
Longer dialogue  $\rightarrow$  higher rapport

- **Results**

Intervention count:  $\beta = -0.032$ ,  $p = .485$

More interventions  $\rightarrow$  lower rapport, but not significant

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# Study limitations

- Address term intervention:  $p1 \neq$  addressee's name
- Interventions possibly interpreted as unintentional (e.g., typos)
  - Interventions occasionally resulted in infelicitous utterances:  
“**Listen**, hmmm 🤔 I didn't see it like this”  
“**Listen**, 🙌”  
“**you** guess that makes him a candidate. What do you think?”
  - Different levels of English ∴ PTs interpreted as unintentional [reported]
  - Regardless of language proficiency, typos are generally expected in messenger chats

# Study limitations

- Assumption that rapport is negatively correlated with confrontation
- Confounding factors affecting rapport evaluation
  - Dialogue length affects opportunity to build rapport [\[reported\]](#)
  - Whether participants share same moral values [\[reported\]](#)
  - Whether attitude towards task is aligned (e.g., serious vs. playful) [\[reported\]](#)
  - Engagement: if participants take long to reply [\[reported\]](#)
- In sum, many downsides to using whole dialogues rather than minimal scenarios

# Motivation for further testing

## One participant's survey responses

| Prompt                                               | Score (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree) | Optionally describe the part of the interaction that motivated this rating. |
|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| I felt I had a connection with my partner.           | 2                                                 | <i>sounds strange when they were calling me p1</i>                          |
| My partner was respectful to me.                     | 2                                                 | <i>again, calling me p1 was not really respectful</i>                       |
| My partner created a sense of distance between us.   | 4                                                 | <i>delays, calling me p1, 'haha' sounding fake</i>                          |
| My partner communicated coldness rather than warmth. | 5                                                 | <i>calling me p1, 'listen'</i>                                              |

# Motivation for further testing

## Another participant's survey responses

| Prompt                           | Score (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree) | Optionally describe the part of the interaction that motivated this rating.                                                                 |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| My partner was warm and caring.  | 2                                                 | <i>Certain choice of wordings, like starting a turn with "Listen,..." or calling me "p2" made me feel that this person was a bit bossy.</i> |
| My partner was respectful to me. | 2                                                 | <i>Again, starting with "Listen,..." felt a bit disrespectful</i>                                                                           |

## Motivation for further testing



***Listen***, here's th- here's the thing, ***Peter***.

*You're stepping over the line now.*

*You're stepping over the line and ***you know you are***.*

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# Conclusion and reframing the RQ

- No consistent support that the 3 potential triggers systematically trigger confrontation
- Sometimes they do, sometimes not

1 DNI: ((smiling)) I know what  
you're gonna say **Saffron**.

2 SAF: ((smiles widely and raises  
eyebrows))

3 DNI: a l ah h h h ((laughing,  
sweeps hand towards  
Saffron))

4 SAF: slid in someone's DMs?  
((smiling, moves toward Dani  
and crosses arms on table))



# Conclusion and reframing the RQ

- **New RQ** In which contexts do these potential triggers trigger confrontation?



- **Narrower scope RQ** In which contexts are potential triggers face-damaging (and in which contexts are they not)?

# Future work

**RQ** In which contexts are potential triggers face-damaging (and in which contexts are they not)?

**Hypothesis** These actions intensify whatever interpersonal dynamic is contextually pre-established.

*I love you, **Chloe**.* → affiliative (face-enhancing)

*I hate you, **Chloe**.* → offensive (face-damaging)

Address terms are used with “particularly significant or sincere” utterances (Clayman 2010)

## In sum

- The 3 analysed potential triggers do not systematically trigger confrontation
- But still, they may play a role in managing interpersonal dynamics
- The relation between these actions, their context, and face effects is worth further investigation

Thank you

# References

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